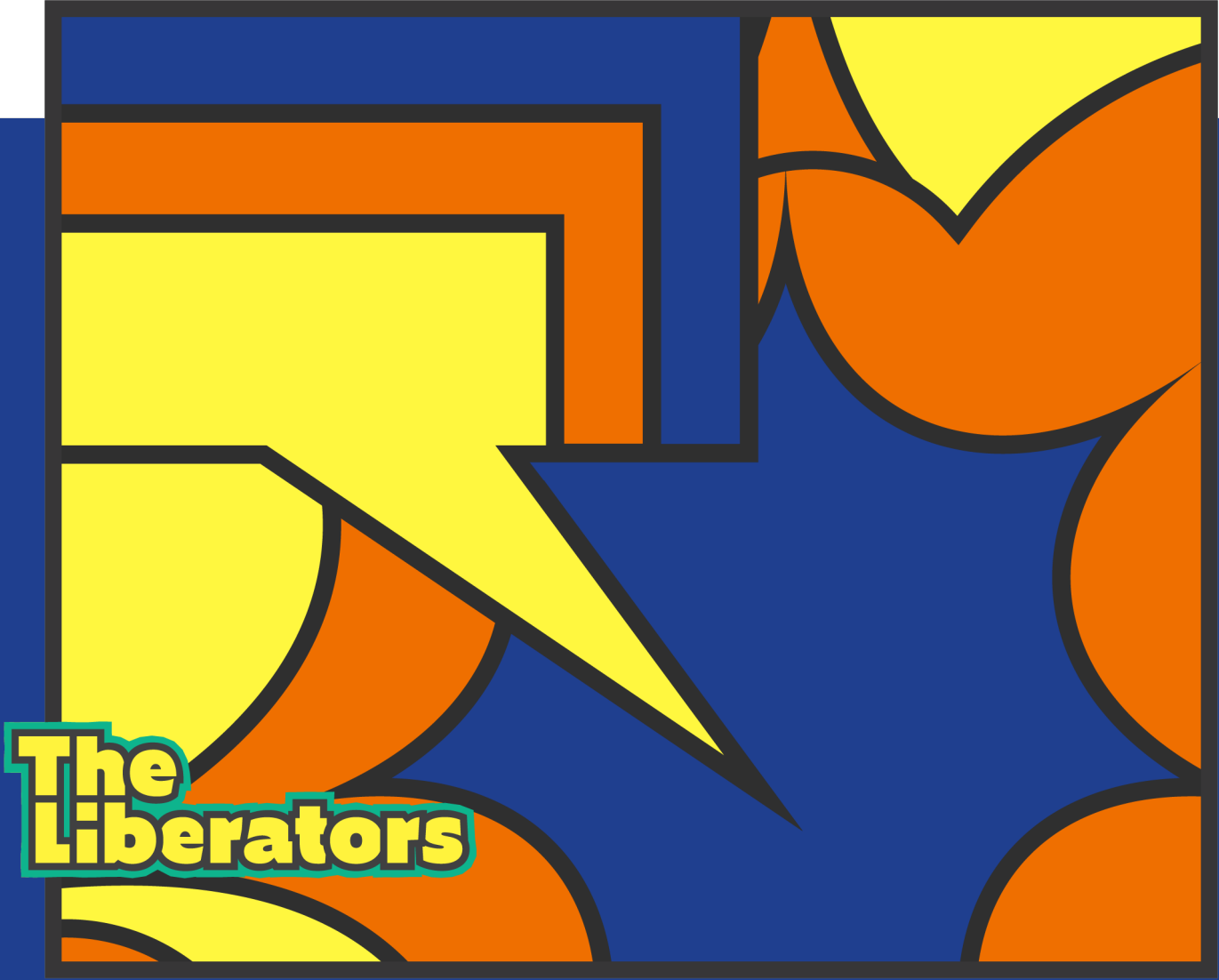


Make The Wicked Question Of Your Scrum Team Transparent

A do-it-yourself workshop to help Scrum teams articulate the paradoxical challenges they face and find imaginative solutions to navigate them

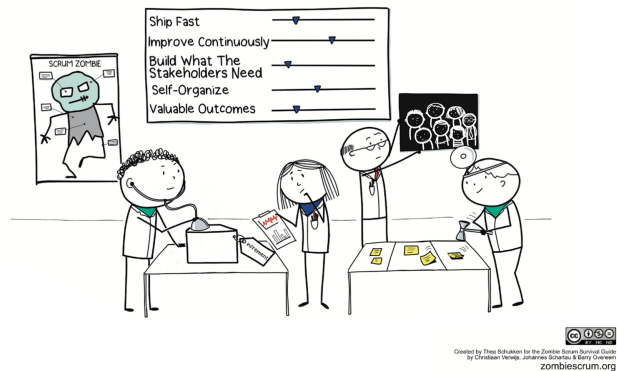


**The
Liberators**

Purpose Of This Workshop

"I see Wicked Questions everywhere now", confided a Scrum Master in us when we helped her become aware of them.

One of the characteristics of complex work is that it is full of contradictory and competing goals. Although each is equally valid and worthy of pursuit, they create tension or open conflict when they are pursued together. In a simple world, we can resolve this tension by letting go of one goal over the other. But that luxury doesn't exist in complex work. Wicked Questions really are everywhere once you start looking for them. Also in how teams and organizations work with Scrum. For example:



A question they often struggle with is:

"How can we encourage autonomous Scrum Teams while also moving towards a shared Product Goal with other teams?"

Or:

"How can we accept the unpredictability of complex work on the one hand while developing a clear strategy towards the future on the other?"

When organizations launch initiatives to start with Scrum, XP, or Kanban, Wicked Questions inevitably emerge and create tension. Unfortunately, organizations either don't address these questions, and their tension, or they pretend they don't exist at all. But under the surface, the tension festers.

The purpose of this workshop is to help your Scrum team articulate the paradoxical challenge they must face in order to succeed. And to help your team(s) move from either/or- to yes/and-thinking, and find solutions that address both sides of the Wicked Question.

Give this string a try, and let us know the results!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators

Flow



Step 1: Opening

 2 min

Step 2: Wicked Questions

  45 min

Step 3: Find Actions That Boost Both Integration And Autonomy

  30 min

Step 4: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

  10 min

Step 5: Closing

 3 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



Creating a specific Wicked Question can be challenging.

Impact On Survival



Making the Wicked Question a Scrum team must face transparent, sets the foundation to resolve the tension, conflict, and impediments.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. We've successfully scaled it up to 100 participants (both virtually and in-person) without significant issues.

Intended Audience

You can run this string with pretty much any audience. We've used it with communities of Scrum Masters, new Scrum teams, with the Dutch Liberating Structures User Group, with our own meetups of The Liberators Network.

Virtual Delivery

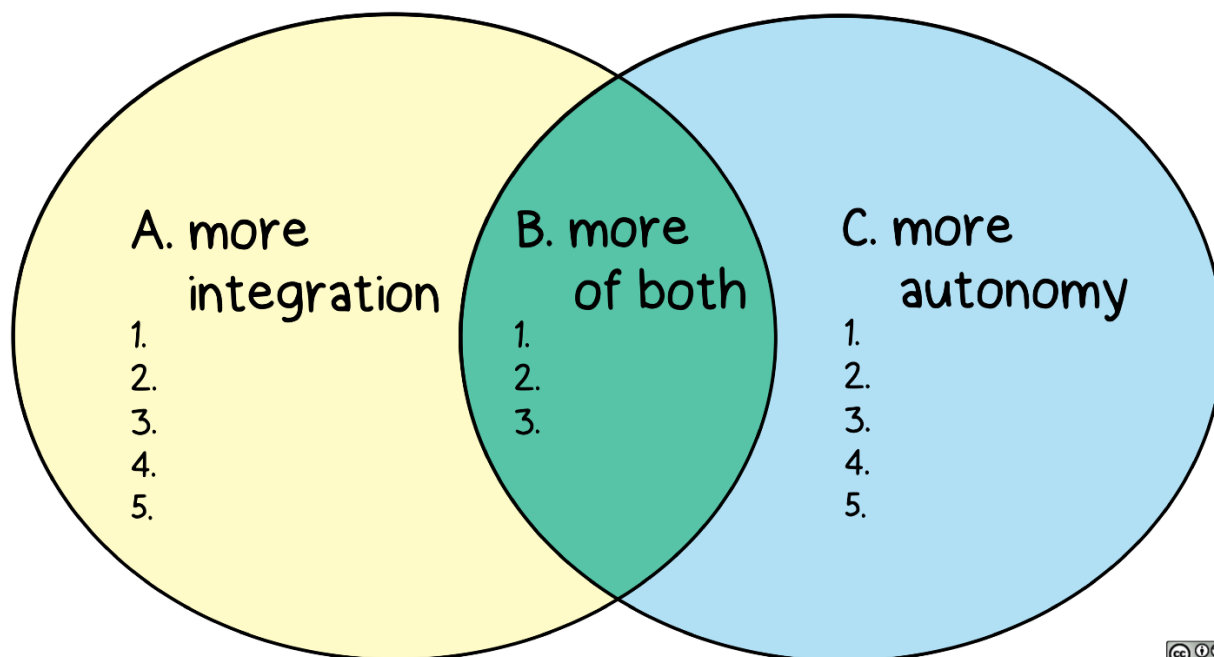
Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Material

- The worksheet "Integrated~Autonomy". When delivered online, create a virtual worksheet.
- A 100-sheet block of tearable [15% Solution-cards](#), ready to be filled out by members in your team.

Resources

- Blog post: [Articulating paradoxical challenges with Wicked Questions](#)
- Blog post: [Move from Either-Or to Both-And Solutions with Integrated~Autonomy](#)
- Blog post: [Trigger BIG change by starting small with '15% Solutions'](#)



model by Henri Lipmanowicz & Keith McCandless


Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



Step 2: Wicked Questions

Wicked Questions help your Scrum team articulate the paradoxical challenges they must confront in order to succeed. It offers them strategic insights and helps them explore new possibilities. The purpose of Wicked Questions is not to find a single answer, but to create transparency about paradoxical realities that exist side-by-side.

Invitation

"What opposing-yet-complementary realities must we face as a Scrum team in order to be successful?"

Steps

- **2 min** Give a short introduction to Wicked Questions and explain the next steps;
- **8 min** First alone, then in small groups, make a list of everything you know is true about being a successful Scrum team (e.g. "we must collaborate on items rather than working apart" or "we must work closely with stakeholders");
- **5 min** Introduce the concept of Wicked Questions by giving some examples;

"How is it that you are raising your children to be very loyal/attached to the family and very independent individuals simultaneously?"

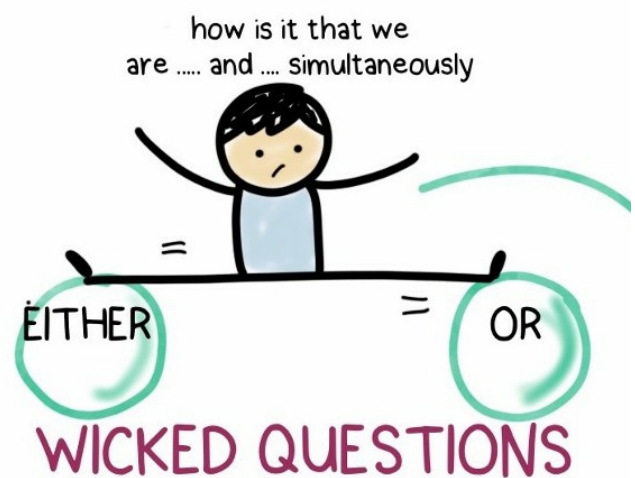
"How is it that I am simultaneously dedicated to my work and being fully present for my family?"

"How is that we want to create as much space to work with focus towards the Sprint Goal while also making time to gather and collaborate about next steps?"

- **12 min** First alone, then in small groups, generate pairs of opposites or pairs where there exists at least (creative) tension between the sides and both sides are positive goals that are worthy of pursuit in the eyes of your team.
- **12 min** First alone, then in small groups, create potential Wicked Questions out of the pairs by using the template below:

"How is that we are [side 1] and [side 2], simultaneously?"

- **5 min** Each group selects the most impactful question and shares it with the entire Scrum team. Pick the most powerful ones and as a Scrum team, refine it further. Make sure that you pick a question that is truly Wicked, in



that both sides are positive, worthy of pursuit, and desirable in the eyes of your team;

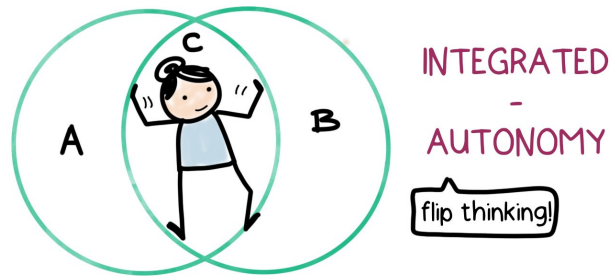
Our Findings

- It may be hard for people to identify Wicked Questions when this is the first time they're doing it. We've all grown up in a world where complexity is often ignored or pushed away in favor of simple solutions. But there are always participants who totally get it and discover many Wicked Questions.
- Offer your own examples of Wicked Questions; this helps the group understand the concept more quickly;
- Set expectations. It's ok when not everyone creates the perfect Wicked Question. Having one good question as a group is already a great achievement.
- Start the different rounds with one minute of individual thinking. This gives everyone the opportunity to get their own thinking started.



Step 3: Find Actions That Boost Both Integration And Autonomy

When faced with a Wicked Question — like 'Should we take better care of our planet or allow our economy to grow' — we tend to shift into either/or thinking. We often assume that we can do only one of both. And this means that all our strategies and solutions will reflect that one-sided approach. But more often than not, there are solutions that promote both sides. How can we take better care of the planet *and* allow our economy to grow? How can spend more time on innovation *and* production? Integrated~Autonomy can be used to find solutions that satisfy both sides of a Wicked Question.



Steps

- **2 min** Use the Wicked Question the team defined in the previous step, as the starting point for Integrated~Autonomy. Make sure the question is visible for everyone;
- **5 min** Introduce the idea of Integrated~Autonomy and explain how it is connected to Wicked Questions. Share the worksheet of Integrated~Autonomy. Distribute a (virtual) copy for everyone in the Scrum team. The names of both sides (Integration and Autonomy) are just one example of a recurring Wicked Question that most organizations face, but we'll replace them with both sides of the Wicked Question;
- **5 min** First individually, then in small groups, invite participants to develop and list actions that help achieve or make possible [Side A];
- **5 min** First individually, then in small groups, invite participants to develop and list actions that help achieve or make possible [Side B];
- **5 min** First individually, then in small groups, invite participants to consider which actions from the lists boost both sides of the Wicked Question;
- **5 min** First individually, then in small groups, invite participants to consider which actions to promote one side can be modified or creatively re-interpreted to promote both sides. Ask "What modifications or creative ideas can be adapted to move actions from left to the center or from right to the center?". Encourage groups to prioritize them;
- **5 min** Debrief the different completed worksheets of Integrated~Autonomy with the entire group and notice patterns and key takeaways.

Our Findings

- Integrated~Autonomy is perfectly suited for problem-solving and strategizing. It helps groups adopt a more holistic view of a challenge they face. Instead of steering the group in one direction of possible solutions, it actively invites them to uncover solutions that work across the field.
- Coming up with specific and tangible actions can be difficult. Keep asking "How would you do that for us?" or "What would that look like here?" in order to move groups beyond abstract ideas and platitudes (such as "more communication").
- If you have a large group, you can make each group of four responsible for one of the actions you identified during step 2. Let them fill in the entire worksheet in their small group from the perspective of that action.
- When doing this workshop online, you can keep the small groups in the same breakout room for all the steps, and only invite them back in the main channel after the final step. This helps them keep focus and makes it easier to stick within the time-box.

Step 4: Identify Personal Next Steps With 15% Solutions

End on a personal note by asking everyone what it is that they want to contribute to the success of their Scrum team. No matter how small, if everyone makes one small change, together this generates large change. The Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) is super useful for this.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to help your team make progress on the Wicked Question and the actions defined with Integrated-Autonomy?"

Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partners find ways to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

Step 5: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this meetup?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

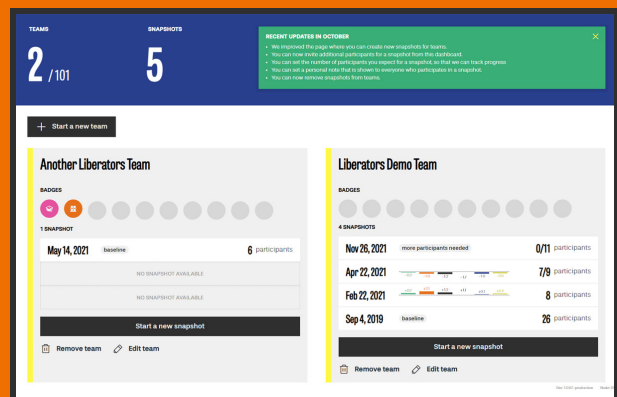
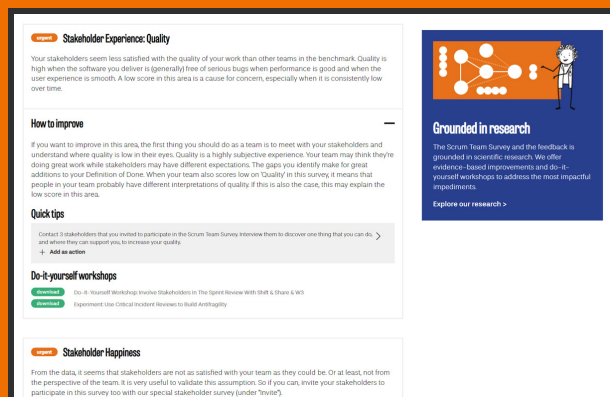
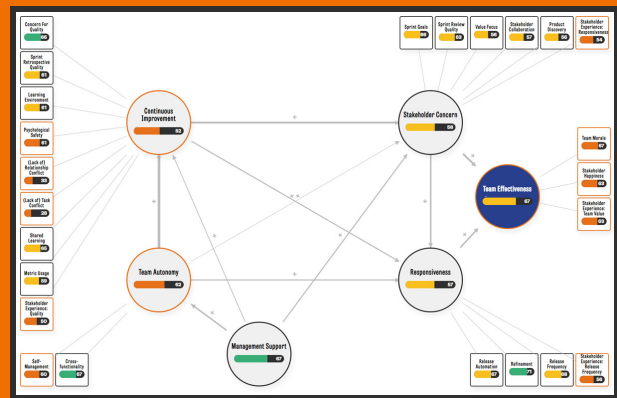
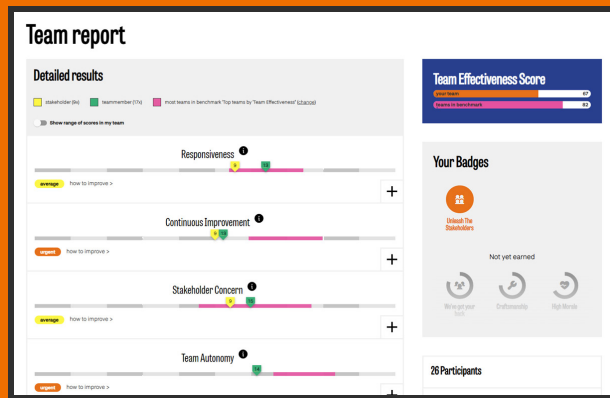
Thank everyone for their presence and announce when the next meetup will take place.

If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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